Zscaler Deployments & Operations

URL Filtering Deployment and Operations Guide

This guide describes the benefits of using URL filtering and the steps necessary for configuring Zscaler Internet Access (ZIA) to add URL filtering to your security posture. To learn more, see About URL Filtering.

You can define a filtering policy that restricts or prevents access to websites based on criteria such as URL categories, users, groups, departments, locations, and time intervals.

Value of Deploying URL Filtering

Using URL Filtering provides the following benefits:

- Limits exposure to certain types of web content.
- Controls access privileges for your users.
- Defines access to custom allowlists and denylists.

Deployment Phase

The deployment phase includes the process of initially setting up and integrating Zscaler solutions into an existing network infrastructure. During the deployment phase, you configure ZIA URL filtering to meet the needs of your infrastructure. The following sections discuss steps to deploy ZIA URL filtering.

Prerequisites

All ZIA editions include URL filtering features. To learn more, see Zscaler Pricing & Plans.

Deployment Steps

The following steps explain how to deploy URL Filtering:

1. Determine if ZIA should cascade to URL filtering policies after it has already processed your Cloud App Control policies.
2. Decide which destinations (i.e., single websites or whole URL categories) should receive restrictions through URL filtering policies.
3. Decide on a filtering concept:
    - Should the last default rule in your rule set block or allow access to web content? The Zscaler default policy allows access. To learn more about the default Zscaler policy and policy execution, see Configuring the URL Filtering Policy.

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    - Which admins, and their admin ranks, are responsible for policy creation?
    - What is the rule order?
    - What criteria limits access to web content? You can define individual sets of criterion per rule.
    - Are custom URL categories needed for specific destinations (e.g., partner sites).
4. Determine which advanced policy settings to enable and disable.
5. Configure your URL filtering policies.

Considerations

Review the following considerations:

- By default, the Cloud App Control policy takes precedence over the URL filtering policy. To learn more, see Configuring the URL Filtering Policy.
- Cloud App Control policies are better suited to control access to specific web applications (e.g., Meta, Google Drive, GitHub) compared to URL filtering rules.
- When routing Microsoft 365 traffic through the Zscaler cloud, consider enabling the Microsoft One Click Options to apply policies to traffic that meets Microsoft's recommendations automatically.
- ZIA might not enforce rules based on certain criteria if you don't enable SSL inspection or use the Zscaler Client Connector.
- If you only want safe-for-work content served on supported search engines, enable Enforce SafeSearch.

  You must have SSL Inspection enabled in order to enable Enforce SafeSearch.

- URL filtering rules are applied on a first-match basis. To learn more, see URL Filtering Policy and Advanced URL Policy Settings.
- Consider how to treat miscellaneous URL categories. Blocking access to URLs in the miscellaneous category might impact your users' experience if they can't access these sites until the URL is categorized.
- Consider enabling AI/ML-based content categorization. AI/ML content categorization dynamically vets unknown websites by analyzing their content.
- Consider creating additional security policies (e.g., Sandbox, File Type Control, Firewall) even after limiting access through URL filtering rules.
- More specific custom category entries always take precedence. URL filtering rules aren't applied to a category with a wildcard if the destination is defined more specifically in another category.

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For example, the first rule CUSTOM_C1 contains .example.com and the second rule CUSTOM_C2 contains www.example.com. When accessing www.example.com, the CUSTOM_C1 policy isn't applied because CUSTOM_C2 is more specific (even though CUSTOM_C1 is higher in the rule order).

Operations Phase

This section describes common practices used to operate Zscaler solutions when integrated with your environment. During the operations phase, you can monitor and tune ZIA URL filtering to meet your infrastructure needs.

Prerequisites

For URL Filtering operation, complete the following prerequisites:

- Document if the Allow Cascading to URL Filtering option is enabled to understand the rule evaluation flow better. This option is located under Advanced Web App Control Options.
- Make sure the operations team has access to the authorization concept.
- Add informative descriptions to your URL filtering rules.
- Agree upon standard operating procedures (SOPs) to add/delete/edit URL filtering rules.
- Agree upon SOPs to add/delete/edit custom URL categories used in your URL policies.

Common Troubleshooting Tips

The following list describes common issues related to URL filtering operation:

- Rules with Request Method or Protocol criteria are not processed as expected: Check if SSL inspection is applied to these transactions. Zscaler might not determine certain criteria if sites are uninspected.
- Rule processing for a site is unexpected: The category check shows it as MISCELLANEOUS_OR_UNKNOWN, but other rules apply. Check if AI/ML categorization is enabled. This feature automatically assigns certain categories to uncategorized sites.
- Allowlist category rule is not applied to certain sites: Check custom categories for more specific entries.
- Website only partially loads, so certain site elements are missing even though access should be allowed: Background elements can be loaded from other sites that could be blocked by your policies. Check the headers for blocked content.
- Applications show TLS error messages: Try turning off SSL inspection for URLs used by this application, since certain applications use certificate pinning and do not function properly if they are not served the original certificate.

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- Wrong category is shown on the blocked page: Check logs to see which category is logged for the transaction. Is the URL in question added to a custom category? If the site is added in the Retaining Parent category, check the rule order to make sure that another rule does not block access to this URL first.

Deployment and Operations Checklist

Zscaler recommends downloading the URL Filtering Deployment and Operations Checklist to help plan and implement ZIA URL filtering: Download PDF

Additional Information

For more URL Filtering information and troubleshooting instructions, see the Zscaler Support Portal and the Zscaler Zenith Community.

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